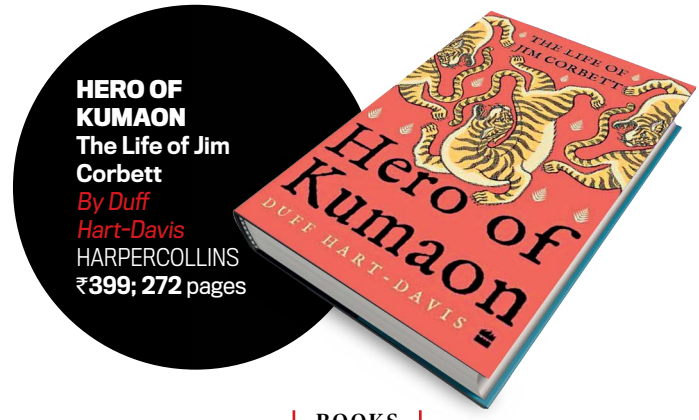
pact of this violence invites comparison with that of the Holocaust, which made the old world of European Jewry (and not only Jewry) virtually inaccessible except through the nostalgia of a few ageing survivors. When we come to 1857, however, there is an important difference: it is as if Hitler and Nazi Germany had won the war. After 1857, there was no Nuremberg, no 'justice', no repentance, no Israel. The surviving victims were condemned to living with the victorious victimisers: the 'guilt' of 1857 was visited solely on the victims, while the vengeful victors became the party of virtue, of progress and modernity. Indeed, and this is crucial: the post-1857 modus vivendi, under vindictive colonial aegis, required that this "virtue" be acknowledged; required that the victims perform, for decades to come, versions of mea culpa, rituals of repentance. Azad and Hali are the hapless and brilliant agents of this act of cultural capitulation—deeply influential, they have bestowed a legacy of self-loathing that has become the default position for the Urdu intellectual, hating his one and only tradition, unable to live with it, unable to live without it. And it is to Russell's undying credit that he enabled Urdu scholars to think through, and beyond this phenomenon, and start a truly heroic act of cultural retrieval. ■

Alok Rai



HERO OF KUMAON
The Life of Jim Corbett
By Duff Hart-Davis
HARPERCOLLINS
₹399; 272 pages

BOOKS

DEEP IN THE WOODS

WAS **JIM CORBETT** A COMPASSIONATE NATURALIST OR AN OPPORTUNISTIC HUNTER? A BIOGRAPHY BY DUFF HART-DAVIS THROWS UP THE QUESTION YET AGAIN

Among the many writings by and about Jim Corbett is the remarkable biography modestly titled *Carpet Sahib: A Life of Jim Corbett* (1986), by Martin Booth. Remarkable not only for the many facets of Corbett's character he brought to the reader, but for the compassion with which Booth renders him a contradictory, fallible, yet endearing man of his time. The new biography by Duff Hart-Davis, coming more than 35 years later, and with its definitive title, was therefore of interest.

While it reads easily, I have to say that I found Hart-Davis's rendering to be part hagiography and part paraphrased and abbreviated versions of Corbett's stories, retaining the raciest parts in Corbett's own words. Hart-Davis's biography works to idealise Corbett and amplify the idea of him having "acquired a god-like reputation as a destroyer of the man-eating big cats..." and that "the hill folk worshipped him...". It fails to give you a feel of the times and the context of the Raj. The bounty hunting, the large-scale degradation of habitats and prey, that, in fact, resulted in the unusually large number of people being killed and eaten by tigers and leopards. Humans, like other primates, have always been killed and eaten by large carnivores. Forest Department data for Kumaon and Garhwal, for just the eight years between 2014 and 2021, shows that leopards attacked 848 people, of whom 162 were killed, and tigers attacked 89 people, of whom 27 were killed.

Corbett was, by all accounts, essentially a *shikari*, a trophy hunter. He would kill whatever he could, skin it, and take it home; an old elephant for its only tusk, and leopards and tigers, whether or not they were man-eaters. He'd even stone to death a magnificent king cobra that meant him no harm and was going its way, for the superstition that killing it would bring him luck in shooting his next tiger. Most of the tigers and leopards that he shot were from the safety of a tree or a *machan*, with tethered bait or a fresh kill under it. He was often aided by armed hordes of beaters; 298 men, "armed with guns, axes, rusty swords and spears" for the tigress of Champawat, and around 2,000 men with several other guns, for the leopard of Rudraprayag. He used strychnine and cyanide to try to poison this leopard, set trip-wired guns on bridges and over dead bodies, and even set out a brutal 80-pound, five-foot-long, iron gin-trap with three-inch-long sharpened teeth on it. And he didn't hesitate while shooting a sleeping tiger.

Then there's the matter of Corbett's fibs. His account of how he tracked down and shot the mother tigress of Chowgarh, eight feet away and ready to spring, while continuing to hold two nightjar eggs in one hand, is outstandingly hilarious. Corbett's friends and many others, including Booth, have pointed these out, but charitably ascribe it to his spicing up his stories, "not for the sake of self-promotion, but just to give a better read". Perhaps the numerous tales of young women, dead and alive, being stripped and carried stark naked by tigers and leopards, and being left largely untouched, other than being "licked by the leopard from the soles of her feet to her neck", were also to this end? ■

Emmanuel Theophilus